Benchmarking Citation Fabrication Rates Across Large Language Models and Agentic Search Tools: A Comparative Review of Fabrication Rates, Detection Methods, and Mitigation Strategies

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Abstract. Citation fabrication—the generation of bibliographic references, case citations, or source attributions that do not correspond to real, verifiable works—has emerged as one of the most consequential and measurable forms of hallucination in large language models (LLMs) and the agentic search systems built on top of them. This survey synthesizes empirical benchmarking work published between 2023 and 2026 that quantifies citation fabrication rates across general-purpose chatbots, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) pipelines, commercial AI legal research tools, and agentic "deep research" systems that autonomously browse and cite web sources. Reported fabrication rates range from roughly 14% to 95% depending on model, domain, and prompting condition, with GPT-3.5-era models fabricating citations in the range of 55%, GPT-4-class models improving to roughly 18%, and RAG-grounded commercial legal tools still hallucinating in 17–33% of tested queries despite explicit "hallucination-free" marketing claims. We organize this literature around a taxonomy of fabrication types (Section 3.1), compare fabrication rates across system types (Table 1), review detection and mitigation approaches (Section 4), and identify open methodological challenges (Section 5). We then extract five evidence-based research gaps, each traced to specific passages of this review and to the original studies, and rank them by feasibility (Section 6); the first three concern how citation verifiers are designed, tuned, and compared, and form the basis of the experimental study that follows this review.

Keywords: citation fabrication; hallucination; large language models; retrieval-augmented generation; agentic search; citation verification; benchmarking; scholarly integrity; deep research agents; legal AI

1 Introduction

The rapid integration of large language models into academic writing, legal research, journalism, and web search has made citation generation one of the most visible and consequential surfaces on which LLM reliability is tested. Unlike many forms of hallucination, which require domain expertise to detect, fabricated citations are in principle externally auditable: a claimed bibliographic reference either resolves to a real, matching work in an authoritative database or it does not. This tractability has made citation fabrication a popular and comparatively rigorous benchmarking target, producing a body of empirical work that spans general-purpose chatbots, retrieval-augmented systems marketed as hallucination-resistant, and increasingly autonomous "agentic" search and deep-research tools that browse the live web and synthesize cited reports on a user's behalf.

The stakes of this problem are not merely academic. Fabricated citations generated by ChatGPT have been implicated in courtroom sanctions after attorneys submitted briefs containing non-existent case law, in the withdrawal of peer-reviewed papers found to cite invented sources, and in the propagation of confidently stated but non-existent scientific evidence in mental-health and biomedical writing (Rao et al., 2026; Dahl et al., 2024; Linardon et al., 2025). As LLMs are embedded ever more deeply into research assistance, legal practice, and "agentic" search products that autonomously retrieve and cite web content, understanding how frequently these systems fabricate citations—and under what conditions—has become an urgent question for scholarly integrity, legal practice, journalism, and public trust in AI-mediated information.

This survey has four aims. First, we characterize how citation fabrication has been operationalized and measured across studies, since inconsistent definitions and verification protocols make cross-study comparison difficult. Second, we compare reported fabrication rates across model families, domains, and system types—general-purpose LLMs, RAG systems, agentic deep-research tools, and generative search engines—to establish where the field currently stands (Section 3.2). Third, we review current detection and mitigation approaches, including how the verifiers themselves are designed and tuned (Section 4). Fourth, we identify the research gaps that remain and trace each to its evidence (Sections 5 and 6). The remainder of the paper is organized as follows: Section 2 reviews foundational and domain-specific literature; Section 3 presents a taxonomy and comparative benchmark landscape; Section 4 surveys detection and mitigation approaches; Section 5 discusses limitations; Section 6 presents the research gaps and future directions; Section 7 concludes.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 Hallucination as a Foundational Concept

Citation fabrication is a specific instance of the broader phenomenon of hallucination in natural language generation, defined by Ji et al. (2023) as generated content that is nonsensical or unfaithful to the provided source material or to verifiable world knowledge. Ji et al. (2023) distinguish intrinsic hallucination, in which output content directly con-

tradicts an available source, from extrinsic hallucination, in which content cannot be verified against the source at all—a category into which most fabricated citations fall, since the model typically has no source document constraining its output and instead generates plausible-looking bibliographic metadata from parametric memory or pattern completion. This distinction matters because it implies that citation fabrication is not primarily a factual-recall failure but a byproduct of how autoregressive language models generate structurally plausible text: a well-formed citation (author names, a plausible title, a real journal name, a numerically plausible year and volume) can be highly fluent while referring to nothing that exists.

2.2 Early Case Studies and the First Systematic Benchmarks

The earliest documented reports of LLM citation fabrication were case studies rather than benchmarks. Alkaissi and McFarlane (2023) reported that when ChatGPT was asked to generate references for two biomedical case reports, all five citations returned for one topic had non-existent titles, and the PubMed identifiers (PMIDs) attached to them pointed to unrelated, real papers—a pattern in which fabricated content is deliberately dressed in genuine-looking identifiers.

The first large-scale, systematic study was conducted by Walters and Wilder (2023), who prompted GPT-3.5 and GPT-4 to generate 84 short literature reviews across 42 multidisciplinary topics and manually verified all 636 resulting citations against library databases. They found that 55% of GPT-3.5's citations were entirely fabricated compared with 18% for GPT-4, and that even among non-fabricated citations, 43% (GPT-3.5) and 24% (GPT-4) contained substantive metadata errors. A work was counted as real if its title and author(s) matched, so a real article with an incorrect journal title was treated as a citation error rather than a fabrication. Fabricated citations almost always used real, existing journal names combined with invented article titles. For GPT-3.5, hyperlinks were more frequent in fabricated citations (18%) than in real ones (5%); for GPT-4 the two rates were similar (8% each). Superficial markers of credibility, such as a working-looking link or a legitimate venue name, therefore do not reliably signal citation validity.

Mugaanyi et al. (2024) extended this line of work across natural-science and humanities topics, finding no significant difference in the rate of entirely non-existent citations between disciplines (approximately 23–27%) but a substantially higher rate of hallucinated DOIs in humanities citations (89.4%) than in natural-science citations (61.8%). Naser (2026) similarly found citation hallucination varying between 11.4% and 56.8% across ten commercially deployed models and four academic domains, strongly shaped by prompt framing; with no prompt asking for citations, none of the ten models produced a formal citation in any of 3,030 responses.

2.3 Domain-Specific Findings: Medicine, Mental Health, and Law

In medical and mental-health domains, fabrication rates show pronounced sensitivity to topic familiarity. Linardon et al. (2025) found that 19.9% of citations across six simulated GPT-4o literature reviews were entirely fabricated, ranging from approximately 6% for a highly familiar disorder to 28–29% for a less-researched disorder. Aljamaan et al. (2024) proposed a "reference hallucination score" to standardize how fabrication severity is quantified across medical AI chatbots.

Legal applications reveal comparably severe outcomes. Dahl et al. (2024) found that general-purpose LLMs hallucinate between 58% (GPT-4) and 88% (Llama 2) of the time on specific, verifiable federal case-law queries. Magesh et al. (2025) subsequently conducted a pre-registered evaluation of commercial RAG-based legal research tools (Lexis+ AI, Westlaw AI-Assisted Research, and Ask Practical Law AI) that market themselves as reducing or avoiding hallucination, finding that these tools still hallucinated in 17–33% of tested queries—directly contradicting vendor claims. Their measure concerns the correctness of answers to legal research queries, which is related to, but broader than, bibliographic citation fabrication.

2.4 Agentic Search and Deep Research Tools

The Tow Center for Digital Journalism tested eight generative AI search engines on 1,600 queries requiring correct source attribution for direct quotations (Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar, 2025). Across all eight tools, incorrect citations were returned more than 60% of the time; the best performer (Perplexity) still erred in 37% of cases, while the worst exceeded 90%. Rao et al. (2026) examined citation URL validity across ten commercial LLMs and deep research agents on the DRBench and ExpertQA benchmarks, reporting that 3–13% of citation URLs are outright hallucinated and 5–18% are non-resolving overall, with deep research agents hallucinating URLs at a higher per-citation rate than search-augmented chatbots despite issuing more citations per query. Xu et al. (2026) (the GhostCite study) benchmarked 13 state-of-the-art LLMs across 40 research domains and analyzed 2.2 million citations from 56,381 papers, finding hallucination rates between 14.23% and 94.93% depending on model, and that 1.07% of sampled published papers themselves contained invalid citations.

3 A Taxonomy and Comparative Benchmark Landscape

3.1 A Taxonomy of Citation Fabrication

Synthesizing the studies reviewed in Section 2, LLM and agentic citation failures can be organized into four overlapping categories, illustrated in Figure 1: (1) *wholesale fabrication*, in which a cited work does not exist under any title, author combination, or identifier—the majority failure mode identified by Walters and Wilder (2023); (2) *metadata corruption*, in which a cited work exists but core bibliographic details are incorrect, affecting 24–43% of nominally "real" citations depending on model generation; (3) *identity mismatch*, in which real author or venue names are attached to fabricated titles, or a genuine identifier is attached to the wrong paper, first documented by Alkaissi and McFarlane

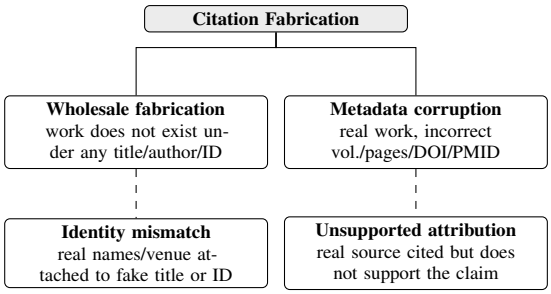


Figure 1: Taxonomy of citation fabrication failure modes identified across the reviewed literature (Section 3.1).

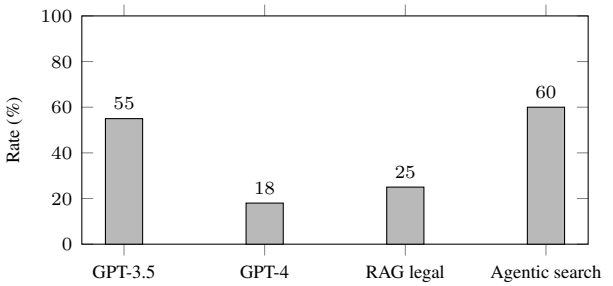


Figure 2: Illustrative fabrication/hallucination rates by system type: base chatbot generation, RAG-grounded legal tools (midpoint of the 17–33% range in Magesh et al., 2025), and agentic web search (Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar, 2025). These come from different tasks and definitions and are not directly comparable; see Table 1 for full ranges.

(2023); and (4) *unsupported attribution*, most prominent in agentic search and news-citation contexts, in which a real source is cited but does not actually support the attributed claim—the central failure mode in Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar (2025). We adopt the distinction between two questions: "does the source exist?" versus "does the source support the claim?". Most of the benchmarks reviewed here answer only the first.

Verifier-side evidence suggests that the boundary between categories (1) and (2) is blurry in practice. In the multi-model audit of Naser (2026), 58.3% of citations that failed the confirmation threshold were scored as "probable real" (similarity 65–79), 31.0% as near misses (50–64), 4.7% as distant chimeras, and only 6.0% as outright fabrications, which led the author to describe the dominant mechanism as distortion rather than invention.

To make comparisons across studies precise, we define the fabrication rate FR for a system evaluated on N_t total generated citations, of which N_f are judged wholly non-existent, as

$$FR = \frac{N_f}{N_t} \times 100\%. \tag{1}$$

Equation (1) underlies the majority of the rates reported in Table 1, although, as discussed in Section 5, studies differ in whether metadata corruption and unsupported attribution are counted toward N_f, which limits direct comparability.

3.2 Comparative Fabrication Rates Across Systems

Table 1 summarizes representative quantitative findings, illustrating both the wide range of reported rates and the systematic factors—model generation, domain, and system architecture—that explain much of this variance. Figure 2 visualizes the headline generational trend reported by Walters and Wilder (2023) alongside the RAG-grounded and agentic figures from Magesh et al. (2025) and Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar (2025).

Four patterns emerge. First, **model scale and generation matter**: the drop from 55% to 18% fabrication reported by Walters and Wilder (2023) is the most frequently cited evidence that later-generation models are meaningfully, though not completely, more reliable citers; however, Naser (2026) report that succession within a developer family does not guarantee improvement. Second, **retrieval augmentation reduces but does not eliminate fabrication**: commercial RAG-based legal tools evaluated by Magesh et al. (2025) still hallucinated in 17–33% of queries despite vendor claims, consistent with the point made by Lewis et al. (2020) that RAG improves factual grounding by conditioning generation on retrieved passages but does not guarantee faithful representation of those passages. Third, **agentic and search-integrated systems are not uniformly more reliable than closed-book chatbots**: the Tow Center's finding that generative search engines erred on direct-quotation attribution more than 60% of the time, and the finding of Rao et al. (2026) that deep research agents hallucinate URLs at higher per-citation rates than search-augmented LLMs, together indicate that adding retrieval or agentic browsing shifts the character of the fabrication problem rather than resolving it. Fourth, **domain and topic familiarity are consistently significant moderators**, with fabrication rates rising for less prominent topics and humanities contexts (Linardon et al., 2025; Mugaanyi et al., 2024).

3.3 Why Citation Presence Itself Can Be Destabilizing

Khurana et al. (2026), in the AuthorityBench study, used a fully balanced 2×2 factorial design crossing claim veracity with citation veracity across general knowledge, science, law, and medicine, evaluating seven models on 220,564 prompts. They found that citation presence—real or fabricated—increased hallucination rates relative to a no-citation baseline in every model tested, an effect strongest when a fabricated citation was attached to an otherwise true claim (pushing agreement with an unrelated or incorrect elaboration up by 3 to 22 percentage points, and as high as 35–77% in general-knowledge domains). Because agentic search products routinely attach citations as a credibility signal, citation-augmented generation can make models more, rather than less, prone to confidently asserting unsupported content.

4 Detection and Mitigation Approaches

4.1 Retrieval-Augmented Generation

The dominant architectural mitigation strategy is retrieval-augmented generation, introduced by Lewis et al. (2020), in which a generator conditions its output on passages retrieved from an external, non-parametric knowledge source rather than relying solely on weights. In practice, Magesh et al. (2025) show that RAG substantially reduces but does not eliminate hallucination, because retrieval can fail silently, generators can still misattribute retrieved content, and multi-step queries often require synthesis across several documents in ways that reintroduce fabrication.

4.2 Sampling-Based and Black-Box Detection

Where model internals or retrieval provenance are unavailable, detection has relied on black-box, sampling-based methods. Manakul et al. (2023) introduced SelfCheckGPT, a zero-resource approach exploiting the principle that independently sampled responses to the same prompt will agree if a model genuinely "knows" a fact, whereas hallucinated content will vary across samples. Naser (2026) apply a related consensus idea to citations: titles produced by three or more of the ten tested models matched his verification pipeline 95.6% of the time, compared with 16.5% for titles produced by a single model (a 5.8-fold difference). This is a match rate against the author's own pipeline, not an independently verified accuracy.

4.3 Post-Hoc Verification Pipelines

A growing body of applied tooling focuses on post-hoc, database-grounded verification, but the designs differ in ways that matter for what they can detect.

Xu et al. (Xu et al., 2026) developed CiteVerifier, which parses reference strings (GROBID, with an LLM re-parser as fallback) and verifies them through a cascade of a local cache, a local DBLP index and Google Scholar, web search, and a re-parse step. A citation is classified as valid if the highest normalized Levenshtein title similarity among retrieved candidates exceeds a threshold of $\theta = 0.9$, a value the authors justify from the empirical distribution of title similarities (only 0.4% of real-paper citations fall at or below 0.9, versus 50.3% of LLM-generated citations). The classification uses *title similarity only*; the authors note that this may undercount hallucinations that closely resemble real papers.

Naser (Naser, 2026) verifies citations against CrossRef, OpenAlex, and Semantic Scholar with a weighted score (title 0.6, author overlap 0.2, year 0.2); a score of at least 80 is "confirmed" and 65–79 "probable". Recomputing hallucination rates at the 65 cut-off preserved the overall ranking only partially (Spearman $\rho = 0.758$) and moved one model from sixth to tenth. The pipeline was checked on a stratified sample of 225 citations using GPT-4.1-mini with web search, which found 8 of 75 citations classified as hallucinated to be real.

Rao et al. (Rao et al., 2026) cross-check cited URLs against the Internet Archive's Wayback Machine to distinguish genuinely non-existent (hallucinated) links from merely non-resolving (link-rotted) ones, and explore correction, not just flagging.

Xu et al. also tested whether LLMs can act as verifiers: 13 models were each asked to judge 100 bibliographic entries (50 valid, 50 invalid), and average accuracy was 38%, below the 50% expected from guessing. Table 2 compares the three mitigation families.

Table 1: Comparison of detection and mitigation approaches (Section 4).

Approach	Mechanism	Key limitation
RAG grounding	Condition generation on retrieved passages (Lewis et al., 2020)	Silent retrieval failure; synthesis-stage drift (Magesh et al., 2025)
Sampling consistency	Cross-sample and cross-model agreement (Manakul et al., 2023; Naser, 2026)	No external ground truth; costly at scale
Post-hoc verification	Database/URL matching (Xu et al., 2026; Rao et al., 2026; Naser, 2026)	Needs an authoritative index; does not prevent generation; thresholds chosen per study

5 Research Challenges and Limitations

Several methodological and structural limitations complicate direct comparison across the studies discussed in Section 3.2.

- **Definitional inconsistency:** studies vary in how strictly they define "fabrication," with some counting only wholly non-existent works and others also counting metadata errors or unsupported attribution, making the raw rates in Table 1 difficult to compare without attention to methodology (cf. Eq. (1), the existence-only criterion of Rao et al. 2026, the title-only matching of Xu et al. 2026, and the broader criteria of Walters and Wilder 2023).
- **Small, non-representative early samples:** several foundational studies rely on fewer than 700 total citations across a handful of topics (Walters and Wilder, 2023; Mugaanyi et al., 2024), raising generalizability questions.
- **Verification labor and scalability:** manual database verification does not scale to the hundreds of thousands of citations examined in recent audits, forcing a shift toward automated matching pipelines whose own error rates are not always independently validated.
- **Unvalidated verifier settings:** the similarity thresholds that decide whether a citation counts as "valid" are chosen separately in each study (0.9 in Xu et al. 2026; 80 and 65 in Naser 2026), and changing the cut-off can change model rankings.
- **Rapid model turnover:** commercial LLMs and agentic products update frequently, often without public changelogs, so benchmark results may not remain valid even months later, and few studies re-test longitudinally.
- **Opacity of commercial agentic systems:** deep research

Table 2: Representative fabrication/hallucination rates across systems and studies (see Section 3.2).

System / Study	Year	Fabrication / Hallucination Rate	Source
ChatGPT (GPT-3.5), literature reviews	2023	55% of citations fabricated; 43% of real citations erroneous	Walters and Wilder (2023)
ChatGPT (GPT-4), literature reviews	2023	18% of citations fabricated; 24% of real citations erroneous	Walters and Wilder (2023)
GPT-3.5, natural sciences vs. humanities	2024	27.3% (sciences) vs. 23.4% (humanities) non-existent; DOI hallucination 61.8–89.4%	Mugaanyi et al. (2024)
GPT-4o, mental-health literature reviews	2025	19.9% overall; 6% (high-familiarity) to 28–29% (low-familiarity) topic	Linardon et al. (2025)
13 commercial LLMs, 40 research domains	2026	14.2%–94.9% across the 13 models	Xu et al. (2026)
10 commercial LLMs, cross-model audit	2026	11.4%–56.8% across the 10 models	Naser (2026)
Legal LLM queries (case citations)	2024	58%–88% hallucination depending on model/query type	Dahl et al. (2024)
Commercial AI legal research tools (RAG)	2025	17%–33% hallucination despite retrieval grounding	Magesh et al. (2025)
8 generative AI search engines, news attribution	2025	60%+ incorrect overall (37% best to ∼94% worst)	Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar (2025)
10 LLMs / deep research agents, citation URLs	2026	3–13% hallucinated URLs; 5–18% non-resolving; agents > search-augmented LLMs	Rao et al. (2026)

agents and generative search engines are closed systems whose retrieval and citation logic are undocumented, limiting diagnosis of where in the pipeline a failure originates (Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar, 2025; Rao et al., 2026).

- **Domain and language skew:** most benchmarks concentrate on English biomedical, legal, and computer-science domains, leaving humanities and non-English scholarship under-studied despite evidence of higher fabrication rates there (Mugaanyi et al., 2024).

6 Research Gaps and Future Directions

6.1 Evidence-Based Research Gaps

Table 3 lists five research gaps extracted from this review. For each, we give where it arises in the review, what the original studies report, and an experiment that would test it. The gaps are our own inferences from the cited evidence; no separate literature search for novelty has been carried out, so none is claimed to be new. Gaps G1–G3 are the most feasible and form the basis of the experimental study that follows this review; G4 and G5 are left for future work.

6.2 Future Directions

Building on Section 5, we propose the following priorities:

1. **Standardized, multi-category fabrication metrics,** extending early efforts such as the reference hallucination score of Aljamaan et al. (2024), that consistently distinguish the four taxonomy categories in Figure 1.
2. **Continuous, longitudinal benchmarking infrastructure** analogous to model leaderboards, tracking the same commercial LLMs, RAG products, and agentic tools over time.
3. **Benchmarks that jointly test existence and support** (gap G5), since most of the benchmarks reviewed here measure whether a source exists rather than whether it supports the claim, particularly for agentic search tools.
4. **Open, reproducible verification infrastructure** for publishers, courts, and newsrooms, integrating tools such as CiteVerifier (Xu et al., 2026) directly into manuscript-submission and legal e-filing systems, together with head-to-head comparison and threshold reporting for such verifiers (gaps G1 and G2).
5. **Causal and mechanistic understanding of fabrication,** connecting it to training-data density, decoding strategy, and calibration research such as SelfCheckGPT (Manakul et al., 2023).
6. **Equity-focused evaluation,** given preliminary evidence that fabrication disadvantages humanities, non-English, and lower-resource scholarship (Mugaanyi et al., 2024).
7. **User-facing calibration and interface design,** since AuthorityBench-style findings (Khurana et al., 2026) show citation presence itself increases trust independent of validity, motivating confidence indicators and mandatory link-checking before display.

7 Conclusion

Citation fabrication has moved from an anecdotal curiosity noted in early ChatGPT case studies to a rigorously, if unevenly, benchmarked property of large language models and the agentic systems built upon them. The empirical record assembled in Section 2 and summarized in Table 1 shows clear, if incomplete, progress: fabrication rates have fallen substantially from GPT-3.5-era levels near 55% to GPT-4-class levels near 18–20%, and retrieval-augmented legal tools, though not free of hallucination, landed in the 17–33% range despite being marketed as avoiding it. At the same time, the newest and most autonomous category of tool—agentic deep research systems and generative search engines—has not resolved the problem and in some respects has introduced new failure modes, including high rates of misattribution to real-but-wrong sources (Section 3.1) and

Table 3: Research gaps identified from this review (Section 6.1). "Evidence" cites the original studies; "Test" states the experiment that would address the gap.

ID	Gap	Where in this review	Evidence in the original studies	Test
G1	Verifier designs have not been compared on one labeled set	Sec. 4.3, 5, 6	Title-only match ($\theta = 0.9$) with DBLP/Google Scholar (Xu et al., 2026); weighted title/author/year score with CrossRef, OpenAlex, Semantic Scholar (Naser, 2026); URL liveness via Wayback Machine (Rao et al., 2026)	Run DOI resolution, title-only and weighted matching on one hand-labeled citation set; report precision, recall, F1
G2	Verifier thresholds and error rates are not independently validated	Sec. 4.3, 5	$\theta = 0.9$ chosen from a similarity distribution (Xu et al., 2026); moving from the 80 to the 65 cut-off changed model ranks ($\rho = 0.758$) and was checked on 225 citations (Naser, 2026)	Sweep each threshold; plot precision–recall; compare published settings with the sweep
G3	Title-correct citations with wrong details (metadata corruption) may be missed by title-only checks	Sec. 2.2, 3.1, 4.3	24–43% of real citations carry metadata errors (Walters and Wilder, 2023); 58.3% of non-matched citations were "probable real" and 31.0% near misses (Naser, 2026); title-only checking may undercount close imitations (Xu et al., 2026)	Label citations by error type (fabricated, wrong metadata, wrong identifier) and report which verifier misses which
G4	LLMs are unreliable as citation checkers, yet LLM-based validation is used	Sec. 4.3 (added)	Average accuracy of 38% over 100 entries for 13 LLMs (Xu et al., 2026); validation with GPT-4.1-mini plus web search on 225 citations (Naser, 2026)	Compare an LLM judge with the database verifiers on the same labeled set
G5	Existence is checked far more often than whether the source supports the claim	Sec. 3.1, 6.2	Most benchmarks measure existence or metadata (Walters and Wilder, 2023; Xu et al., 2026; Naser, 2026; Rao et al., 2026); attribution is studied mainly for news quotations (Jaźwińska and Chandrasekar, 2025)	Read each genuine source and judge whether it supports the claim it is cited for

elevated per-citation hallucination despite producing more citations overall. The verifiers used to measure all of this are themselves designed and tuned differently from study to study, which limits how far reported rates can be compared (Table 3, G1–G3). As these tools become further embedded in scholarly publishing, legal practice, and everyday information-seeking, the research community's priority should shift from repeatedly re-discovering that fabrication occurs toward building the standardized metrics, validated verifiers, longitudinal benchmarks, and verification infrastructure outlined in Section 6.

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